

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called Mekhalā (The Girdle)

Ārya Maikhalā-nāma-dhāraṇī · Toh 772 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་མཁའ་ལ་ནམ་བུའི་གྲི་ཐུང་།

The Noble Dhāraṇī called Mekhala (Sanskrit: Ārya Maikhalā-nāma-dhāraṇī; Tibetan: Phagpa Nöndzin gyi Tsen Gya Tsa Gyépa, the "Hundred and Eight Names of the Noble Graha-Holder") is a protective text of the dhāraṇī type, concerned with guarding against harm attributed to graha spirits, the seizing forces often blamed for afflictions of children. The narrative follows a young boy named Rāhu-seized, who was frightened by a rākṣasa, and who then goes to the Buddha, who was staying in the Nyagrodha Grove at Kapilavastu among the Śākyas, to seek help. The text offers a protective formula, the dhāraṇī itself, together with a litany of names, and is meant to be used for safety and healing. It is Toh 772 in the Kangyur, belonging to the Tantra section, where it is classed among the dhāraṇī texts.

Atha vāka deva yakṣa samaya manusmara hrīḥ hūṃ phaṭ svāhā. Here is completed the one hundred and eight names of the Noble Graha-Holder.

In the language of India: Ārya Maikhalā-nāma-dhāraṇī. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Dhāraṇī called Mekhala.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling in the land of the Śākyas, at the place called Kapilavastu, in the Nyagrodha Grove, the Kunadgarāma. At that time a young boy named Rāhu-seized (Grahagrasta) was lying on his bed, when a rākṣasa (flesh-eating demon) frightened him.

Then, when that very night had passed, the boy Rāhu-seized, driven forward and surrounded on all sides by many boys, set out from Kapilavastu. He went to where the Blessed One was, and on arriving, bowed his head to the feet of the Blessed One, sat down before him, and wept.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, in order to protect the boy Rāhu-seized, I shall teach the knowledge-mantra called Mekhala. You must hold it.

"Assemblies of gods, assemblies of nāgas, assemblies of yakṣas, assemblies of rākṣasas, assemblies of asuras, assemblies of garuḍas, assemblies of kinnaras, assemblies of mahoragas, assemblies of flesh-eaters, assemblies of pretas,

assemblies of kumbhāṇḍas, assemblies of pūtanas, assemblies of planets, assemblies of constellations, the twenty-eight commanders of the yakṣas, the four great kings, the seers free from desire, whatever beings dwell on the earth, whatever beings are present in the ten directions, assemblies of rākṣasīs, Pāli, Kāṭalidi, Bodari, Grongrna, Yidzang, the Great Seizer, assemblies of the mother-goddesses, listen to me.

"As guardians of the retinue of the ocean: in the eastern quarter is the rākṣasī called Seizer; in the southern quarter is the rākṣasī called Elephant-Nose; in the western quarter is the rākṣasī called Matted-Hair; in the northern quarter is the rākṣasī called Crown-of-the-Earth. Each of these fierce rākṣasīs is surrounded by a retinue of six hundred thousand. Protect, with all that is spoken in the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala."

Tadyathā: ghana ghane, ghane ghane, ghane ghane, ghane ghane vati; ghume ghume, ghume ghume, ghume ghume, ghume ghume vati; ghare ghare, ghare ghare, ghare ghare, ghare ghare; ghiri riṇi; gharvati svarvati; dhanavati; survati; ahi; mevati; mati; apati; supati; bahuvasi; hala hala, hala hala, hala hala, hala hala; hili hili, hili hili, hili hili, hili hili; hulu hulu, hulu hulu, hulu hulu, hulu hulu; tili tili, tili tili, tili tili, tili tili; hili hili; mili mili; petayava; amane; mavisare; ha ha; hi hi; samantrasare; asamantrasare; parikhasame; avarte samantavarte; ghane; mekhale.

"Ānanda, this one called Mekhala is mighty, of great miraculous power, and of great diligence. She goes everywhere unobstructed and unhindered by holders of knowledge-mantras, by spirits, and by those who raise the dead.

"Ānanda, this knowledge-mantra called Mekhala was spoken by the buddhas, the Blessed Ones of the past, for the benefit and happiness of beings, and for the purpose of guarding and concealing them. Other great seers have also said: Ānanda, the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala brings benefit to beings."

"All those who are possessed of evil deeds, who dwell as seizers of vitality, hearing the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala, will be seized with terror and flee to the directions and the intermediate directions. Ānanda, for one who has well grasped the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala, let protection be made on every side for twelve yojanas. Let there be complete safeguarding, complete holding, complete nurturing, and let there be peace and well-being. Homage to the Buddha. Abandon punishment. Abandon weapons, and quench poison. Turn back the hostile. Let the boundary be fixed. Let it be bound with a thread. Turn back all hatred. Let no human or non-human who does evil cause harm.

Homage to the Buddha. May the foundations of the secret mantra be accomplished. Svāhā.

"As for the ritual: pay homage to the Tathāgata, offer flowers and incense, and bind a thread. Let the one who performs it be anointed and bathed well. By this ritual all spirits are turned back and all illnesses are completely pacified.

Tadyathā: tile, pele, vimale, tamale, hili nirisiri, masara.

"Once this knowledge-mantra has been heard,
all the lands will tremble.

The hosts of spirits will be greatly shaken,
and the hosts of gods will come.

The kings of the nāgas will come,
the kings of spirits will come.

The Blessed One Maitreya too will go there.

Brahmā and Indra will come,
and the Great Lord and the Youth, Kumāra,
both of them will come there.

Whichever spirits are named in the Mekhala,
they too will come."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Maitreya, addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, I too shall grant protection, complete safeguarding, complete holding, peace and well-being, the abandoning of punishment, the abandoning of weapons, the quenching of poison, the turning back of the hostile, the boundary of nine, and complete protection from the Mekhala."

Tadyathā: abaṭṭani, baṭṭani, ibibaṭṭani, culu cili, urdhadānte, samantadānte, nirmuṇḍe, nimimuni. "May there be peace and well-being. Svāhā. Homage to the Buddha. May there be well-being. Svāhā."

Then, at that time, Brahmā, lord of the Sahā world, offered this circle of words for fully upholding the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: aṃgure, adure, dudure, śikhi śikhi śikhi śikhi śikhi, vare, dhara dhara pati, muca muca, vimuca. "May there be peace and well-being. Svāhā."

Then, at that time, the son of the gods Raṇavigata, "Free from Strife," offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: braduṣṭe, rudhirakarṇe, gaṃbhīre, durdarśane, muce muce, śākyarāje. "May there be well-being. Svāhā."

Then, at that time, Śakra (Indra), lord of the gods, offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: soḍḍe, bhedeḍe, bhedaḍame, danti li, tilimili. "Protect. May there be well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā."

Then, at that time, the great king Virūdhaka, "Bad Body," offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: ghume ghume, ghume ghume ghume, uke, muke, jvale, dale, matiphale, svāre, sara adhipati. "May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā."

Then, at that time, the great king Dhṛtarāṣṭra, "Protector of the Realm," offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: dhadhare, dhadhare, dhāraṇi dhāraṇi, dhāre acyute muce, muru muru.

May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done extensively, as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the great king Virūpākṣa, "Born of the Noble Ones," offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: aṇḍare, paṇḍare, karaḍe, parapatre, karirūhe, karibhare, kanakapatre, rurume, kṣukṣu, akṣime, bakṣi. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then the great king Virūpākṣa, "Ugly Eyes," offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: jamala jamala, dhiri dhiri, bhiri bhiri bhiri, samantabhiri. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the son of the gods, the Moon, offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: alahe, telabhe, maḍe, vimaḍe, bhake, dharake, sakini, bakini. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the son of the gods, the Sun, offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: oṃ vāde, vimale prabhāsvare, śahara smehasahasra smara atasvarasi. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the assemblies of the gods offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: kuru kuru, suru suru, muru muru. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the assemblies of the constellations offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: tamala tale, ahe, dahe, ākāśavimale. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the assemblies of the nāgas offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: ele, mele, acale, badhe, āśubadhe, mokṣe. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the assemblies of the asuras offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: adhadhare, vipute, saṃpute, danti. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the twenty-eight generals of the yakṣas offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: cacavati, cacavati, rurudrā rā, ubhirabhara. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the assemblies of the pretas, the flesh-eaters, and the kumbhāṇḍas offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: bhūti vibhūti, atibhūti, sabartanbhūti. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the assemblies of the rākṣasas and the corpse-demons offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: phadume, kārāḍe, adhita, cute, samiraṇi, cucuvati. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, all the assemblies of the mātṛkās offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: kele makele, ḍama, kele paḍare, ḍamare, ḍaḍare. May there be peace and well-being. Let it be done as far as the boundary of nine. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the four great rākṣasīs of the four directions offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: ānabani, khaje khabaje, khukhu, riri, miri, hiri. May there be peace and well-being.

As far as the boundary of nine, let it be done. Svāhā.

Then, at that time, the great sister, Groling-ma (the sister who moves through the sky), offered a circle of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala.

Syād yathedam: darade, darade, ha ha, hi hi, hu hu hu hu, śi ki, klibā klibā, makhu makhu, juka khi, ṭa phaṭabi, aṭṭyura ṭṭyura, klama, kuju kuju, dri dri dri, dū dū dū, ci mi li, mi li, aṭa, kva kva, kvakasi, du du, ti thi ti thi, ti mi li, mi ti, śi ti, mi ti li, bati, preti preti ṇe, duhini, ahāni, hale, bahe, thaṭa baithabe.

Venerable one, this is the knowledge-mantra of Groling-ma, offered as a circle of the dhāraṇī-mantra of Mekhala.

For protection, for complete safeguarding, for complete holding, for complete shielding, for peace and well-being, for the abandoning of punishment, for the abandoning of weapons, for the neutralizing of poison, for the turning back of enmity, let the boundary be set and complete protection be made, to a distance of twelve yojanas, as far as the boundary of nine.

Whether gods, or nāgas, or yakṣas, or rākṣasas, or kumbhāṇḍas, or flesh-eaters, or scent-eaters, or hungry ghosts, or crawling beings, or body-crawling beings, or asuras, or garuḍas, or kinnaras, or mahoragas, or those who cause drying up, or cause forgetting, or cause madness, or cause killing, or spell-casters, or corpse-raisers, or those who bring a one-day fever, a two-day fever, a three-day fever, or a four-day fever, whether human or non-human, may none of them cause harm. Whoever seeks to cause harm, to injure, to watch for an opening, or to search for an opening and find one, there is no ground for it, except for the ripening of previous karma. May there always be well-being, free from all dangers, from all humans, and from all

non-humans. Svāhā.

Then the Blessed One said to the venerable Ānanda: "Ānanda, take up the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala together with its retinue. Ānanda, this knowledge-mantra of Mekhala binds clouds, subdues winds, cuts off hail, protects oneself, protects others, protects villages and towns, and sets boundaries. It cannot be transgressed by gods, or nāgas, or yakṣas, or rākṣasas, or hungry ghosts, or kumbhāṇḍas, or flesh-eaters, or body-crawling beings, or ascetics, or brahmins, or wandering mendicants, or roving renunciants, or naked ascetics, or those who live by ritual livelihood, or skull-bearers, or those with bodies of ash, or by humans or non-humans.

Ānanda, this knowledge-mantra of Mekhala destroys all killers, spell-casters, and corpse-raisers. It turns back all possessing spirits. It destroys all inauspiciousness.

Ānanda, this knowledge-mantra of Mekhala cuts off what has been done by ascetics. It cuts off the knowledge-mantras made by brahmins, by wandering mendicants, by roving renunciants, and by those who live by ritual livelihood. It cuts off the knowledge-mantras made by the Great Lord (Maheśvara). It cuts off those made by Brahmā, by Indra, by the king of the gods, by the Great King, by Viṣṇu, and by the lord of desire. It cuts off those made by the Great Kings, by the commander of the yakṣas, by the moon and the sun, and by the stars and planets. It cuts off the knowledge-mantras made by gods, nāgas, yakṣas, rākṣasas, scent-eaters, asuras, garuḍas, kinnaras, and mahoragas. It cuts off those made by possessors of miraculous power. It cuts off those made by temple-dwellers. It cuts off those made by cemetery-dwellers. It cuts off those made by dwellers at the foot of trees, and

It cuts off the knowledge-mantras made by those who dwell at the foot of mountains, by those who dwell on mountain peaks, by those of the earth, by those of the sky, by those of every place, by humans, and by non-humans. This knowledge-mantra of Mekhala cuts off. It cuts off in return. It cuts off afterward.

Ānanda, whoever is protected, guarded, upheld, and sustained by this knowledge-mantra of Mekhala becomes peaceful and well; punishments are averted, weapons are averted, poison is neutralized, and hostility is turned back. Having set a boundary of one league, or two leagues, or up to twelve leagues, if anyone were to transgress this knowledge-mantra of Mekhala, then in the world with its gods, with its māras, with its Brahmās, with its ascetics

and brahmins, in the world of beings including gods, humans, and asuras, I have seen no such one. That is impossible.

Ānanda, by the truth of all the buddhas, by the truth of the Dharma, by the truth of the Saṅgha, by the truth of all who speak truth, and by the truth of all the sages, let no assembly of beings act against this. Ānanda, these are the five that must not be transgressed in any time: the truth of the Buddha must not be transgressed; the truth of the Dharma must not be transgressed; the truth of the Saṅgha must not be transgressed; the truth of those who speak truth must not be transgressed; the truth of the sages must not be transgressed. They are not to be transgressed by any spirits, any diseases, any humans, or any non-humans.

May there be well-being from all diseases, all spirits, all hatreds, and all enmities. Let no one cause any disturbance. Let no one cause harm. Let no one strike anyone. Svāhā.

The ritual procedure of the knowledge-mantra of Mekhala shall be explained. Having offered flowers, incense, perfumes, and food offerings to the Buddha, one should afterward perform the protection. Clean, and wearing clean clothes, one smears a maṇḍala with cow dung and scatters flowers. Whatever one can obtain, whether a torma, or flour, or lotuses, or food and drink mixed with flowers, one fills a vase or a vessel with these. Sitting in the middle, one should burn incense without interruption. For all rites, one should perform the rite with kuśa grass. To protect oneself and to protect others, one uses a thread.

To bind the clouds, one makes a fire offering with the wood of flowering trees and with fragrant butter. To turn back wind and rain, one recites over a blade of muñja grass three times, then, having applied the root knowledge-mantra seven times, ties and then undoes seven knots. To accomplish the road and to ensure well-being, one recites over the corner of one's Dharma robe seven times, three times over, and then undoes three knots.

Having eaten the three white foods and fasted for three days and nights, one recites twenty-one times over lotuses and white mustard seeds, and thereby sets a boundary around a village or a town. If one wishes to cut off all knowledge-mantras, one recites seven times over various weapons and cuts them in water. If one pours water into a clean vessel, recites seven times, and bathes with it, all misleading spirits will be bound. If one recites over white flowers and strikes with them, one becomes free of poison. For all diseases,

one performs the rite with a twig of the karavīra tree. If one performs the protection of oneself, then all rites can be done anywhere, even against possession. And fights and

And in order to quell quarrels and divisions, or within a king's palace and its surroundings, one recites over kindling sticks that have been smeared with the oil of fragrant flowers and with clarified butter and atimuktaka flowers, using the knowledge-mantra of the garuda, and one makes a fire offering fourteen times.

If one wishes to bring spirits under one's power, one recites the garuda knowledge-mantra over kindling sticks of the apāmārga plant, together with goat's milk and goat's butter, and makes the fire offering five times.

If one wishes to perform a fire offering for the sake of all beings, one takes thick rice porridge, milk, rock salt, mustard, and kindling sticks of the white karavīra tree. One recites the mantra twenty-one times and makes the fire offering. Then the fire offering will have been made for the sake of all sentient beings.

For the sake of obtaining what one needs, one recites the garuda knowledge-mantra seven times over rock salt and clarified butter, washes one's face, and speaks. Then whatever one asks for will be obtained.

In every case, one should honor the Tathāgata, or a stūpa of the Tathāgata, with incense, garlands, ointments, flowers, fumigations, and powders, and offer food offerings as well, as far as one is able. Together with protection and together with the proper ritual, may all sentient beings, without exception, be protected. Svāhā. This is the accomplishment.

When the Blessed One had spoken thus, the venerable Ānanda, the youth Rāhula, that entire assembly together with it, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This concludes the noble dhāraṇī called Mekhala.

It was translated, revised, and finalized by the Indian preceptor Prajñāvarman and the great reviser-translator, the venerable Yeshé dé, together with others.

Translator's Notes

- The opening mantra and the mantra string are given in Tibetan transliteration of Sanskrit; I have rendered them in plain romanization, and the readings are only approximate, since the

transliteration is corrupt in places. The name of the boy, rendered "Rāhu-seized," reflects the Tibetan "sgra gcan 'dzin"; the Sanskrit may be Rāhula or Grahagrasta. The Tibetan "sa ser skya'i gnas" is rendered Kapilavastu, and "Kun dga' rab" as the Kunadgarāma, a likely corruption for the Nyagrodha Grove's viḥāra. Several names in the list of rākṣasīs (Pāli, Kāṭhalidi, Bodari, Grongrna) are obscure transliterations and are not translated. The statement that Mekhala is unobstructed by "those who raise the dead" renders "ro langs" (vetāla, corpse-animating spirits). The final lines of the passage appear slightly truncated.

- The mantra syllables are given in the Sanskritized forms shown in the Tibetan, and some are corrupt or uncertain. The Tibetan reads "from Mekhala" and "the Great Lord and the Youth" without naming them. I took these as Maheśvara (Śiva) and Kumāra, and left them as the text has them. The Tibetan "nine boundaries" is unclear in meaning and kept literal. The names of the gods' sons and the two kings are interpretive renderings of the Tibetan epithets: Raṇavigata, Virūḍhaka, Dhṛtarāṣṭra. "Lord of the Sahā world" renders the Tibetan "lord of those who cannot be borne" (mi mjed), the usual epithet of Brahmā.
- The mantra syllables are given as they appear in the Tibetan transliteration, with only light normalization; several strings are corrupt or unrecoverable (for example, "Ṭa ṭa..." forms and the Sun's mantra), and I have not reconstructed them beyond the Tibetan.

The Tibetan names the first king as 'Phags skyes po, which is Virūḍhaka, the guardian of the south, not Virūpākṣa. Since the preceding passage already used Virūḍhaka for "Bad Body," I have kept 'Phags skyes po as Virūpākṣa only as a placeholder for the second occurrence of the name. The ordering of the four kings in this text appears to be confused, and the identification of "Born of the Noble Ones" is uncertain. A reader may wish to check against the Sanskrit or other witnesses. The king here rendered "Ugly Eyes" (Mig mi bzang) is a standard rendering of Virūpākṣa, which makes the doubling more likely a scribal or textual displacement.

The term translated "corpse-demons" renders lus srul po, taken as a class of rākṣasa-like beings; this is a tentative reading.

- The mantra syllables are rendered by transliteration from the Tibetan and are inherently uncertain, as the passage is corrupt in places. The name ཀློང་མ་ is rendered tentatively as Groling-ma; the Sanskrit original is not securely reconstructed. ཀུམ་བླ་མ་ is rendered kumbhāṇḍa. The epithet རྒྱལ་ལོ་པོ་ is rendered Great Lord (Maheśvara). The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as in the source text given.
- The text is a dhāraṇī of Mekhalā (the "girdle" or "belt" knowledge-mantra). I have rendered the name as Mekhala, following the Tibetan transliteration. The Tibetan "grass-hut" or similar reading in the list of cut-off mantras is uncertain; I took the opening phrase as "those who dwell at the foot of mountains," continuing the earlier list. In the instruction on turning back wind and rain, the phrase about reciting over "a blade of muñja grass three times, then applying the root mantra seven times" reflects the Tibetan wording and may be compressed from the Sanskrit. The "corner of the Dharma robe" is a probable reading of the Tibetan; the sequence "seven, three" is somewhat unclear. The final sentence breaks off mid-clause at the passage boundary.
- The mantra name rendered here as garuda knowledge-mantra follows the Tibetan "agro lding ba" (garuḍa). The identification of the plants is by transliteration or conventional rendering: atimuktaka, apāmārga (the Tibetan has a corrupt spelling, "a pa marga"), and karavīra. The Tibetan "gzhon nu sgra gcan 'dzin" is Rāhula, rendered as such. The Tibetan title spells the dhāraṇī's name as "Me kha la," which I have rendered as Mekhala, reconstructing the Sanskrit tentatively. The Tibetan "brgya tsha" is rendered as mustard on contextual grounds. The Tibetan "ru rta" is rock salt per the lexicographic tradition, though some texts use it for costus root. The Tibetan "snying" before the colophon names the translators as Prajñāvarman and Yeshé dé, consistent with the early ninth-century translation team.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.